

Module 1 — The Blueprint

Module purpose

Before training problems begin, the home needs a safe setup.

This module helps a new dog owner create a safe base area, remove common hazards, prepare for the first vet visit, and understand the basic cost reality of dog ownership.

This is not obedience training.

This is the setup layer that prevents avoidable confusion, stress, and escalation.

What the owner should be able to do after this module

By the end of Module 1, the owner should be able to:

1. Set up one safe base area for the dog.
 2. Create a calm rest zone or crate/pen setup without using it as punishment.
 3. Remove common household, garden, food, and medication hazards.
 4. Know when a suspected poisoning needs immediate vet or poison-helpline advice.
 5. Prepare useful questions for the first vet visit.
 6. Understand that the first year of ownership has real routine and unexpected costs.
 7. Know what information to record if later trainer or vet support is needed.
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Lesson 1 — Safe Home and Rest Zone

Scenario

Your new puppy or dog has just arrived home.

At first, they seem quiet. Later, they start pacing, chewing, grabbing things, following people constantly, or struggling to settle. The house feels chaotic, and you are not sure whether this is a training problem or just normal adjustment.

What the owner needs to notice

A new dog needs a smaller, safer starting area before they are given full access to the home.

They need:

- a safe living area
- a comfortable sleeping area
- fresh water
- soft bedding

- safe chew items
- reduced access to hazards
- a place where they can rest without constant interruption

The goal is not to trap the dog.

The goal is to make the home easier to understand.

Common mistake

Giving the dog full freedom too soon.

This often leads to:

- hidden toileting accidents
- unsafe chewing
- stealing items
- overstimulation
- poor rest
- frustration from the owner

Another common mistake is using the crate, pen, or laundry area only after something goes wrong. That teaches the dog that the space predicts isolation or punishment.

Better decision rule

Start small, calm, and safe.

Before giving more freedom, ask:

Can my dog rest safely here without getting into trouble?

If the answer is no, reduce the space and improve the setup.

What to do now

Create one safe base area.

Use a puppy pen, crate with the door open, gated room, or other safe area depending on the dog and home.

The area should include:

- soft bedding
- water
- safe chew item or food puzzle
- non-slip or easy-clean flooring if possible
- no cords, small objects, medicines, bins, toxic plants, or cleaning chemicals within reach
- enough separation from household chaos to allow rest

Keep the setup positive.

Do:

- guide the dog there calmly
- feed treats or meals there
- allow short, relaxed rest periods
- let the dog sleep without interruption

Do not:

- force the dog in angrily
- use the space as punishment
- leave the dog confined for long periods without social contact, toileting, exercise, or comfort
- expect the dog to settle in a noisy or stressful area

Watch for this

Notice whether the dog:

- settles faster in one part of the home
- becomes more frantic after long periods awake
- chews or mouths more when tired
- follows people because they cannot switch off
- panics when placed in the rest area
- sleeps better when household traffic is reduced

When education is not enough

Seek vet or trainer guidance if:

- the dog cannot settle anywhere
- the dog panics in the rest area
- the dog tries to injure themselves escaping confinement
- behaviour changes suddenly
- the dog appears unwell, painful, unusually lethargic, or distressed
- the home cannot be kept safe despite repeated setup changes

Vet/trainer-readiness note

Before asking for help, record:

- where the dog sleeps
 - how long they can rest
 - what happens before they become unsettled
 - what the rest area looks like
 - whether distress starts immediately or after a delay
 - what you have already changed
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Lesson 2 — Household Toxins and Hazards

Scenario

Your dog picks something up from the floor, steals food from a bench, chews a packet, digs near garden products, or mouths something from the laundry, bathroom, garage, or bin.

You are not sure whether it is dangerous.

What the owner needs to notice

Many ordinary household and garden items can seriously harm dogs.

Common risk categories include:

- human medicines
- rat bait and pest-control products
- slug or snail bait
- cleaning chemicals
- laundry products
- batteries
- magnets
- string or small swallowable objects
- some human foods
- xylitol or birch sugar in sugar-free products
- rising dough
- alcohol
- toxic plants
- garden fertilisers and chemicals

A dog does not need to look sick immediately for the situation to be serious.

Common mistake

Waiting to see what happens.

Other unsafe mistakes include:

- trying internet home remedies
- giving milk, oil, food, or water to “dilute” the problem
- inducing vomiting without professional advice
- assuming human medicines are safe for dogs
- assuming a small amount is harmless
- throwing away the packet before calling a vet

Better decision rule

If your dog may have swallowed or contacted a toxin, treat it as a vet question first.

Do not guess.

Do not wait for symptoms.

Do not attempt home treatment unless a vet or poison professional tells you to.

What to do now

1. Move the dog away from the hazard.
2. Prevent further access.
3. Keep the product packet, plant sample, label, or photo if safe to do so.
4. Note:
 5. what the dog may have eaten or contacted
 6. estimated amount
 7. time it happened
 8. dog's weight if known
 9. symptoms already seen
10. Call your vet, emergency vet, or the Animal Poisons Helpline.

For Australia, the Animal Poisons Helpline is:

1300 869 738

Watch for this

Depending on the substance, signs may include:

- vomiting
- diarrhoea
- drooling
- wobbliness
- unusual tiredness
- abdominal pain
- refusal to eat
- bleeding
- tremors
- seizures
- breathing change
- collapse

Some poisonings can worsen before obvious signs appear.

When education is not enough

Immediately.

Suspected poisoning is not a training problem. It is not a wait-and-see problem.

Contact a vet, emergency vet, or poison service if exposure is possible.

Vet/trainer-readiness note

Tell the vet:

- what the dog may have eaten or contacted
- amount
- time
- product name or plant type
- dog's weight
- symptoms
- photos of packaging or plant if available

A trainer only becomes relevant later if the dog repeatedly scavenges, counter-surfs, raids bins, or accesses hazards after the medical risk has been handled.

Lesson 3 — First Vet Visit and Cost Baseline

Scenario

Your dog has arrived home. You have food, bedding, and a few supplies.

Now you are unsure about vaccines, parasite prevention, microchipping, registration, socialisation, desexing, and what the first year may actually cost.

What the owner needs to notice

The first vet visit is not just for vaccines.

It is the first professional baseline for:

- general health
- vaccination timing
- parasite prevention
- microchip status
- registration questions
- diet transition
- weight and growth
- local disease risks
- safe early exposure
- handling worries
- behaviour changes that may be health-related

A vet can tailor advice to the dog, the household, and the local area.

Common mistake

Waiting until there is a problem.

Other common mistakes include:

- going to the vet without questions
- assuming every puppy follows the same risk plan
- relying only on internet advice
- delaying care because early costs were underestimated
- treating sudden behaviour change as a training issue before ruling out health concerns

Better decision rule

Book early and bring notes.

The question is not:

What does the internet say puppies need?

The better question is:

What does this dog need in this local area, with this health history and this home setup?

What to do now

Book the first vet visit.

Bring:

- adoption or breeder paperwork
- vaccination record if available
- microchip details if available
- current food details
- parasite prevention history if known
- notes about appetite, toileting, vomiting, diarrhoea, sleep, coughing, scratching, limping, fear, or handling issues

Ask the vet:

1. What vaccinations does this dog need, and when?
2. What local parasites or diseases should we prevent?
3. Is the microchip registered correctly?
4. What council registration steps apply?
5. How should we handle safe early exposure before full vaccination?
6. What signs should make us call you urgently?
7. What should we do if the dog eats something unsafe?
8. When should desexing be discussed for this specific dog?
9. How can we make vet visits less stressful?
10. Are there any health concerns that could affect behaviour?

Cost baseline

Dog ownership costs more than the purchase or adoption fee.

Australian government guidance from MoneySmart gives current planning figures showing dog ownership can cost several thousand dollars in the first year, with ongoing annual costs after that. Treat these figures as estimates, not guarantees.

Costs may include:

- adoption or purchase fee
- food
- bedding
- harness, lead, collar
- bowls
- toys and chews
- vet visits
- vaccinations
- parasite prevention
- microchipping
- council registration
- grooming if needed
- training support if needed
- emergency vet care
- pet insurance if chosen

Common cost mistake

Budgeting only for food, toys, and the adoption fee.

This can lead to delayed vet care later.

Better cost decision rule

Plan for routine costs and unexpected costs separately.

Ask:

What can I afford every month, and what happens if there is an emergency?

What to do now

Create a simple dog budget with three sections:

Routine

- food
- parasite prevention
- routine vet care
- registration
- grooming if needed

Setup

- bedding
- lead/harness/collar
- safe rest area
- bowls
- toys or chews
- cleaning products

Unexpected

- emergency vet visit
- illness or injury
- urgent medication
- extra training or behaviour support
- transport or boarding if needed

Pet insurance can be considered as one planning option, but it is not automatically suitable for everyone. Compare policies carefully, including exclusions, waiting periods, caps, and what is not covered.

Watch for this

Cost stress becomes a welfare issue when it causes owners to delay necessary care.

Signs this may be happening:

- avoiding vet visits despite symptoms
- skipping prevention because of cost
- delaying treatment
- relying on online advice when the dog may need professional care
- feeling unable to ask the vet about lower-cost options

When education is not enough

Speak to a vet if the dog seems unwell, injured, painful, lethargic, vomiting, has diarrhoea, has eaten something unsafe, or suddenly behaves differently.

Be upfront about budget limits. Vets may be able to discuss priorities, staged care, payment options, or welfare supports.

Vet/trainer-readiness note

Tell the vet:

- what changed
- when it started
- appetite
- toileting
- sleep

- vomiting or diarrhoea
- possible toxin exposure
- pain signs
- handling sensitivity
- budget limits if relevant

Tell a trainer later:

- what setup you have tried
- what the vet has ruled out or advised
- what behaviours continue despite setup changes
- what support is financially realistic

Tool 1 — Safe Home Checklist

Use this before the dog arrives and again at the end of the first week.

Base area

- ☐ One safe living area chosen
- ☐ One comfortable sleeping area prepared
- ☐ Bedding is soft, clean, and dry
- ☐ Water is available
- ☐ Safe chew item or food puzzle available
- ☐ Flooring is safe and easy to clean where possible
- ☐ Area is not too noisy or high-traffic
- ☐ Dog can rest without being constantly touched or disturbed

Hazard removal

- ☐ Human medicines locked away
- ☐ Cleaning chemicals locked away
- ☐ Laundry products out of reach
- ☐ Rat bait, snail bait, and pesticides inaccessible
- ☐ Garden fertilisers secured
- ☐ Bins secured
- ☐ Electrical cords managed
- ☐ Batteries and magnets out of reach
- ☐ String, thread, socks, and small swallowable objects removed
- ☐ Toxic foods kept out of reach
- ☐ Xylitol/birch sugar products checked and secured
- ☐ Toxic plants checked and moved if needed

Rest-zone check

- ☐ Crate, pen, or gated area is used calmly
- ☐ It is not used as punishment
- ☐ Dog is introduced gradually

- ☐ Dog is not left confined for long periods without welfare needs met
- ☐ Dog can settle there, or difficulty settling is being tracked

Emergency preparation

- ☐ Local vet phone number saved
 - ☐ Emergency vet phone number saved
 - ☐ Animal Poisons Helpline number saved: 1300 869 738
 - ☐ Product packets or plant photos will be kept if exposure happens
 - ☐ Household members know not to induce vomiting unless told by a vet or poison service
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Tool 2 — First Vet Visit Checklist

Use this before the first appointment.

Bring

- ☐ Adoption or breeder paperwork
- ☐ Vaccination record
- ☐ Microchip details
- ☐ Current food information
- ☐ Parasite prevention history if known
- ☐ List of current concerns
- ☐ Photos or videos of unusual behaviour if useful
- ☐ Stool or vomit details if relevant
- ☐ Notes about suspected toxin exposure if relevant

Ask the vet

- ☐ What vaccinations does this dog need, and when?
- ☐ What local disease risks matter in our area?
- ☐ What parasite prevention do we need?
- ☐ Is the microchip correctly registered?
- ☐ What council registration applies?
- ☐ What safe early exposure is appropriate before full vaccination?
- ☐ What symptoms should make us call urgently?
- ☐ What should we do if the dog eats something unsafe?
- ☐ When should desexing be discussed for this specific dog?
- ☐ How can we make handling and vet visits less stressful?
- ☐ Could any behaviour concerns be health-related?

Tell the vet

- ☐ Appetite
- ☐ Water intake
- ☐ Toileting pattern
- ☐ Vomiting or diarrhoea
- ☐ Sleep and rest pattern

- ☐ Coughing, scratching, limping, or pain signs
 - ☐ Fear during handling or travel
 - ☐ Sudden behaviour change
 - ☐ Possible access to toxins or hazards
 - ☐ Budget limits if they may affect care planning
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Module completion action

The owner can complete Module 1 when they can confirm:

- ☐ A safe base area is set up
 - ☐ A rest zone or sleeping area is ready
 - ☐ Key household and garden hazards are removed or locked away
 - ☐ Vet and emergency contacts are saved
 - ☐ The first vet visit is booked or planned
 - ☐ First vet questions are prepared
 - ☐ A basic first-year cost plan has been reviewed
 - ☐ The owner knows when to stop self-guided education and contact a vet
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Module 1 dashboard summary

Current focus

Set up the home before problems escalate.

Today's action

Create one safe base area and remove the most obvious hazards.

Capability gained

Safe home setup.

Decision rule

Start small, safe, and calm before giving more freedom.

Escalation reminder

Suspected poisoning, sudden illness, pain, collapse, repeated vomiting, severe lethargy, seizures, or major behaviour change require vet guidance first.

Trainer-readiness output

If problems continue, the owner should be able to describe:

- home setup
 - rest area
 - hazards removed
 - when the problem happens
 - what happens before it
 - what has already been tried
 - whether the vet has been contacted
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Internal source map

This section is for repo/source control only. It should not appear inside the learner flow.

Core source base

Module 1 is supported primarily by:

- RSPCA Australia and RSPCA Knowledgebase for new dog/puppy setup, safe living areas, vaccination questions, and household dangers.
- RSPCA Policy A8 for welfare boundaries around housing, confinement, comfort, movement, and social contact.
- Australian Animal Poisons Helpline for poison triage, emergency instructions, and common poison categories.
- MoneySmart for Australian pet-cost planning and pet insurance cautions.
- AVSAB as Tier 2 support for puppy pens/crates as safe rest spaces, positive veterinary care, humane training principles, and safe early socialisation context.

Claims requiring careful wording

Cost claims

Use as estimates only.

Approved wording:

Australian estimates suggest dog ownership can cost several thousand dollars in the first year, with ongoing annual costs after that.

Avoid:

Your dog will cost exactly X.

Poison claims

Use practical emergency language.

Approved wording:

If poisoning is suspected, call a vet, emergency vet, or Animal Poisons Helpline before trying anything at home.

Avoid:

Try this home treatment.

Crate and rest-zone claims

Use welfare-balanced language.

Approved wording:

A crate or pen can help when it functions as a safe rest space.

Avoid:

Crating fixes behaviour problems.

Socialisation/vaccination overlap

Keep as a first-vet question only in Module 1.

Approved wording:

Ask your vet how to balance vaccination safety with safe early exposure in your local area.

Teach socialisation fully in Module 4.

Desexing

Keep as an “ask your vet” topic only.

Approved wording:

Ask when desexing should be discussed for this specific dog.

Avoid giving timing advice.

Codex implementation note

Store this as:

```
/docs/education/curriculum/01-the-blueprint.md
```

Optional supporting files:

```
/docs/education/research/module-1-the-blueprint-research.md  
/docs/education/research/module-1-claim-register.md  
/docs/education/tools/safe-home-checklist.md  
/docs/education/tools/first-vet-visit-checklist.md
```